



Music streaming has solved access to millions of songs, but meaningful discovery remains limited by repetitive and low-confidence recommendations.

Chosen product: Spotify

[Sources](#)

Streaming is the dominant way the world listens to music.



100M+ tracks available at listeners' fingertips.



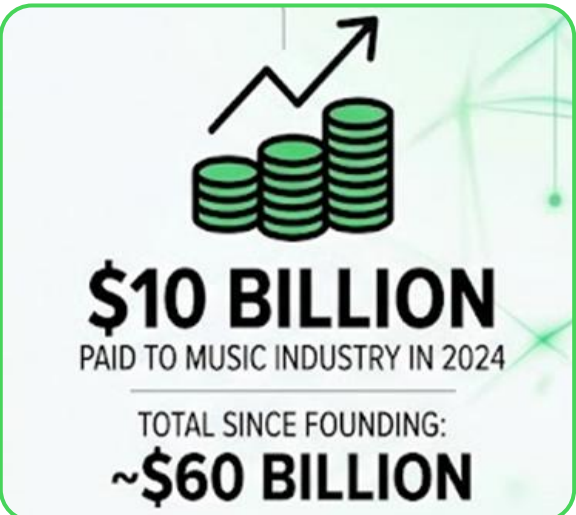
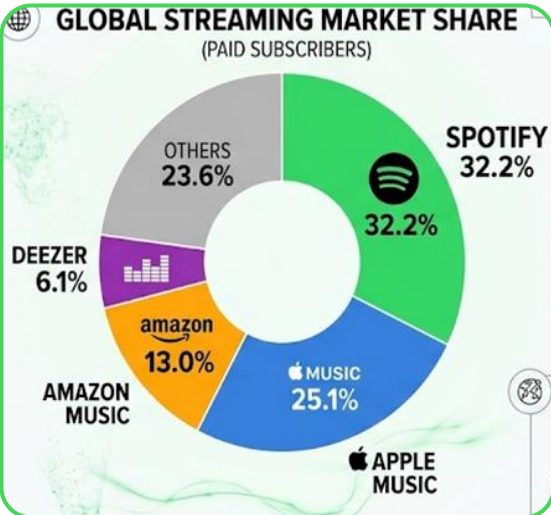
600M+ users globally, 240M+ premium subscribers.



Streaming accounts for ~67% of global recorded music industry revenue.



Competition for user attention comes from short-form video, social media, gaming, podcasts and more.



THE ATTENTION GAP

Millions of tracks

Thousands of recommendations

A small set of songs repeatedly played



KEY MARKET NUMBERS



100M+ Tracks on Spotify



600M+ Users Globally



240M+ Premium Subscribers

~67%
Of Global Recorded Music Revenue from



THE OPPORTUNITY

The market opportunity is not to offer more songs or more playlists; it is to help users confidently move from familiar music to new music without breaking their current mood, activity, or listening flow.





Key User Discovery Challenges and Product Opportunity

COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

Competitors offer discovery, but most optimize for either familiarity, trend relevance, or passive consumption.

Competitor	Discovery strength	Gap / Spotify opportunity
Apple Music 	Strong human-curated playlists and radio	Combine trusted curation with more personalized AI discovery
YouTube Music 	Excellent search for remixes, live tracks, and obscure music	Build a cleaner “deep cuts” and alternate-version discovery flow
Deezer 	Lean-back personalized music stream	Give users novelty controls: Familiar, Balanced, Explore
JioSaavn 	Regional and Indian-language music discovery	Improve cross-language and regional artist discovery
Spotify 	Strong AI recommendations, playlists, and listening-data personalization.	Reduce repetitive recommendations with intent-based, transparent discovery controls.

KEY TAKEAWAY

[Spotify](#) has strong recommendations, but users still get repetitive songs and familiar artists. The opportunity is to give users more control over how much new music they want to discover.

HYPOTHESIS

- Users get trapped in familiar listening patterns**
Recommendations often prioritize previously played songs, favorite artists, and repeat playlists, limiting exposure to genuinely new music.
- Users want discovery control, not only algorithmic recommendations**
Listeners have different intentions—comfort listening, adjacent discovery, genre exploration, or complete surprise—but cannot clearly communicate this to Spotify.
- Users lose trust when recommendations feel repetitive**
When Discover Weekly, Radio, or personalized mixes repeatedly suggest similar songs, users assume the platform does not understand their evolving taste.
- Users need intentional discovery pathways, not more playlists**
Rather than adding more recommendation surfaces, Spotify should help users choose their desired novelty level: Familiar, Balanced, Explore, or Surprise.

QUANTITATIVE REASEARCH

[Survey](#)

[RESPONSES](#)



- 63.4% stream primarily on Spotify, making it the dominant platform.
- 75.6% listen to the same songs, artists, or playlists repeatedly (almost always/often).
- 73.2% discover new music via social media, vs. only ~25% through in-app recommendations.
- 51.2% are dissatisfied with current recommendations (mean score just 2.6/5).
- 31.7% say suggestions "don't match my mood" — the single biggest discovery challenge.
- 29.3% want a mix of familiar songs plus fresh recommendations.
- 85.4% rate a mood- and freshness-aware AI assistant as useful (4–5 out of 5).

Key takeaway

- Users are stuck on repeat; apps fail to break the loop.
- Discovery happens outside the app, not via recommendations.
- Low satisfaction, high demand for a mood-aware AI assistant.
- The gap is mood and freshness control, not better matching.

SOURCE MIX AND METHOD

[RAG](#)



App Store		100
Play Store		1200
Reddit		550

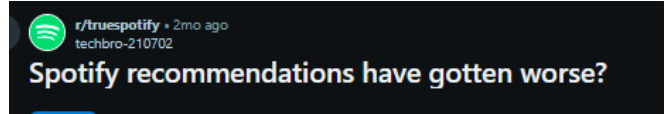
METHOD

- 1,850 unique public feedback records collected from App Store, Play Store, and seven Reddit discussions.
- Each record classified with a constrained schema; obvious non-discovery false positives removed conservatively.
- Deterministic aggregation ranks themes across the complete 266-record discovery subset.
- RAG supplies explanations and citations, never prevalence.

INTERPRETATION RULES

Multi-label, self-selected, complaint-enriched. Rank signals; do not infer Spotify-wide prevalence.

QUALITATIVE REASEARCH



- "Would you use an AI that builds playlists from your mood?"
- If an AI actually asked me my mood + how adventurous I'm feeling before building a playlist, I'd use it daily. That's the missing piece.
- "Recommendation engines are getting worse, or is it just me?"
- Rated my recs a solid 2/5 lately. It either plays it too safe (stuff I know) or throws random noise at me. No in-between.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Stuck on repeat; algorithm recycles saved songs.

Discovery moved to social media, not the app.

Recs feel "too safe or too random."

Mood mismatch is the real problem.

Users want mood + freshness control (AI assistant).



USER SEGMENT

Weekly listeners who intentionally seek unfamiliar music and already spend effort recovering from poor discovery.

JOB TO BE DONE

When I want music beyond my current rotation, help me find unfamiliar options that fit what I want right now, so I can explore without losing relevance or training my long-term profile by trial and error.

MEERA · UNIVERSITY STUDENT



18F · full-time student · campus/PG or family home · study-heavy routine
Keep study music focused, but help me escape the same rotation.

PAIN POINTS

- Study sessions drift into the same familiar cluster
- Temporary or shared listening can influence later recommendations
- Manual playlist building and external discovery consume limited time

BEHAVIOR

- Uses focus playlists, Discover Weekly, friends, and Shazam
- Falls back to a trusted playlist when early recommendations miss

ROHAN · SOFTWARE DEVELOPER



24M · software developer · hybrid/remote · tier-1 or tier-2 city · large library
A large library should not collapse into the same small focus loop.

PAIN POINTS

- A 4,000-song library can feel like roughly 100 recurring tracks
- The same artists recur across focus, workout, and discovery mixes
- Repeated skipping breaks concentration and still feels ineffective

BEHAVIOR

- Uses large liked-song libraries, radio, Smart Shuffle, and generated mixes
- Cleans playlists or searches externally when rotation narrows

MAYA · MARKETING EXECUTIVE



38F · marketing executive · urban · commute/work/event contexts · time-constrained
Give me fresh music for this moment—not only what is already popular.

PAIN POINTS

- Popular or safe recommendations crowd out meaningful novelty
- The same artists leak across unrelated listening contexts
- Feedback does not make the next set visibly different

BEHAVIOR

- Fast context switching
- Control over popularity and novelty
- A useful set in under a minute

INTERVIEW : Walk me through the last time discovery disappointed you. • What did you expect, and which first signal told you it was wrong?
• What did you do next, and why did that feel easier than correcting Spotify? • Tell me about a recent discovery experience that worked well.



What is the true problem?

Spotify’s Discovery Is Not Context-Aware or User-Controlled

Spotify relies heavily on past listening behavior, so recommendations repeatedly favor familiar artists, songs, and playlists. Users cannot easily tell Spotify whether they want to stay focused, explore adjacent music, or discover something completely new for their current moment.

What are the customer facing this problem?

The primary customers facing this problem are heavy daily listeners, students and focus listeners, music explorers, mood- and activity-based listeners, and niche or regional music listeners. These users often want fresh music for a specific moment, but receive repetitive recommendations based mainly on their past listening history.

How do we know its real problem?

User reviews and online discussions frequently mention repetitive recommendations and difficulty finding relevant new music. Listening behavior shows users repeatedly return to familiar playlists and artists. Interviews validate that users want new music but avoid discovery due to irrelevant suggestions and high skip effort.
This confirms a clear gap: users need controlled, low-risk music exploration.

Value for target customers

Spotify helps users discover fresh, relevant music for their current mood, activity, or intent—without losing the comfort of their existing preferences. This reduces repetitive listening, saves time spent searching, and makes music discovery feel more personal and effortless

Value for the business

This improves user engagement by increasing discovery-feature usage, saves, follows, and repeat plays of newly discovered music. It can reduce listening fatigue and churn among heavy users, strengthen Spotify’s personalization differentiation, and create more opportunities to promote emerging artists and premium discovery experiences.

Why solve this problem now?

- Discovery is a core engagement behavior; Spotify reports nearly 2B music discoveries every 24 hours.
- Natural-language playlist tools are emerging, but a complete inspectable correction loop remains fragmented.
- A deployed prototype now makes the riskiest interaction assumptions testable without production integration.



Solution Prioritization: Selecting Discovery Compass as the Highest-Impact MVP

1. DISCOVERY COMPASS

CHOSEN

CONCEPT

Create a separate tab as Discovery compass - an editable session contract before ranking and a visible steering loop after each recommendation set.

EVIDENCE FIT

Addresses taste mismatch, repetition, similarity, popularity bias, and weak correction in one testable loop

MAIN RISK

Intent entry may add friction or fail to improve base candidates

2. TRANSPARENT DISCOVERY FEED

CONCEPT

Explain why each track appears and expose diversify, dislike, and exclusion controls directly in the feed.

EVIDENCE FIT

Makes feedback legible and is relatively easy to test

MAIN RISK

Only six records explicitly lack explanations; transparency cannot rescue weak relevance

3. TASTE PROFILE REPAIR CENTER

CONCEPT

Let users inspect and remove artists, genres, or temporary contexts believed to influence recommendations.

EVIDENCE FIT

Strong response to profile contamination and requests to forget inputs

MAIN RISK

Requires trustworthy causal explanations of a complex production profile

DIRECTIONAL ICE PRIORITY

Rank	Solution	I	C	E	Score
1	Discovery Compass	9	7	6	378
2	Transparent Discovery Feed	6	5	4	120
3	Taste Profile Repair Center	8	6	8	384

WHAT CHANGES THE RANKING

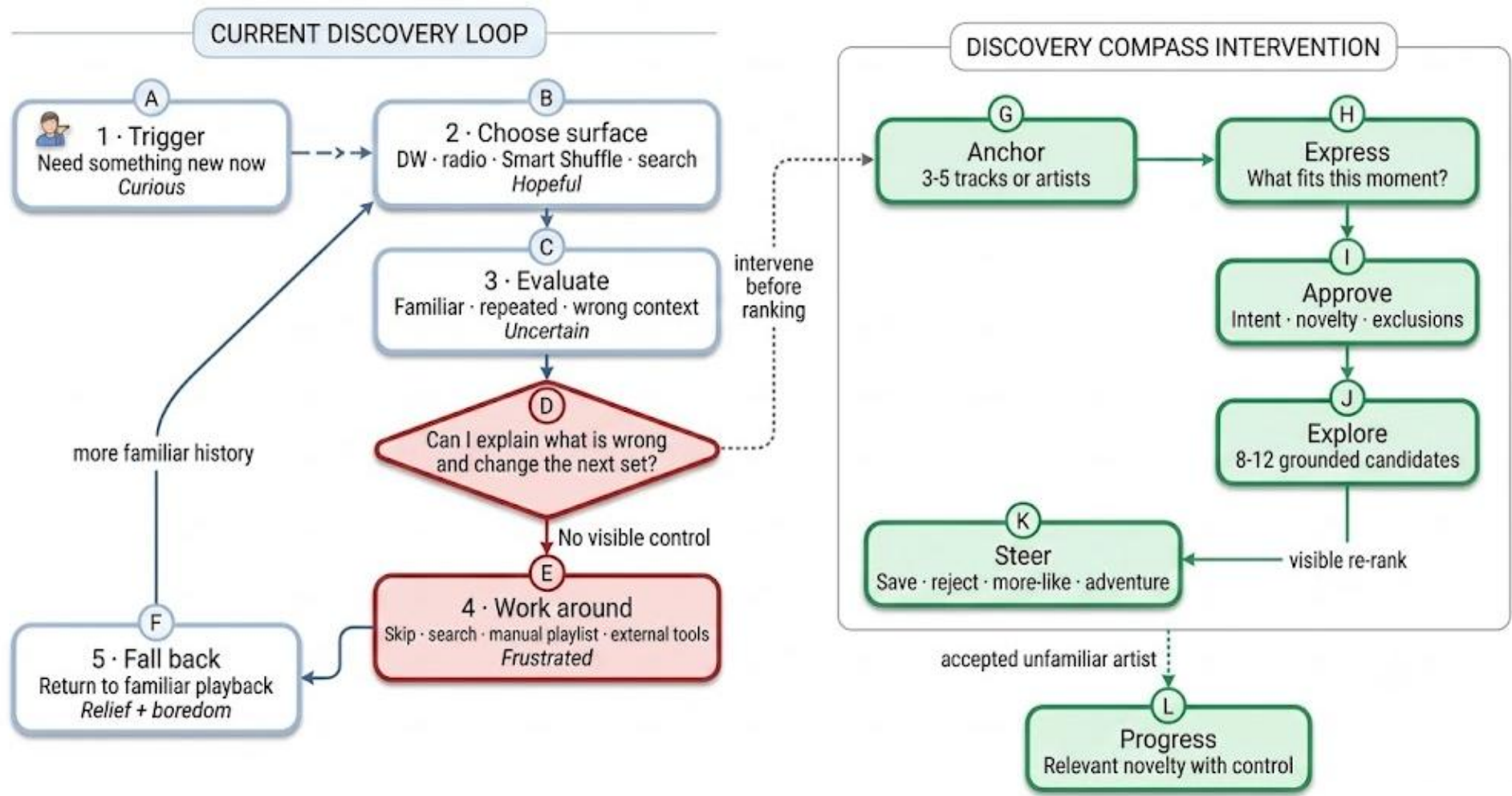
If intent setup is rejected but correction is valued → pivot to Transparent Feed. • If profile contamination dominates interviews → prioritize read-only Profile Repair. • If base candidate quality dominates both conditions → stop interaction expansion and fix catalog coverage.

Why Discovery Compass Goes First

- Addresses repetition, poor relevance, and lack of discovery control.
- Tests whether current intent improves new-music acceptance.
- Easy to launch, reversible, and does not alter long-term user profiles.
- Other ideas can follow after validating this core need.



Discovery Compass: From Repetitive Listening to Confident Exploration

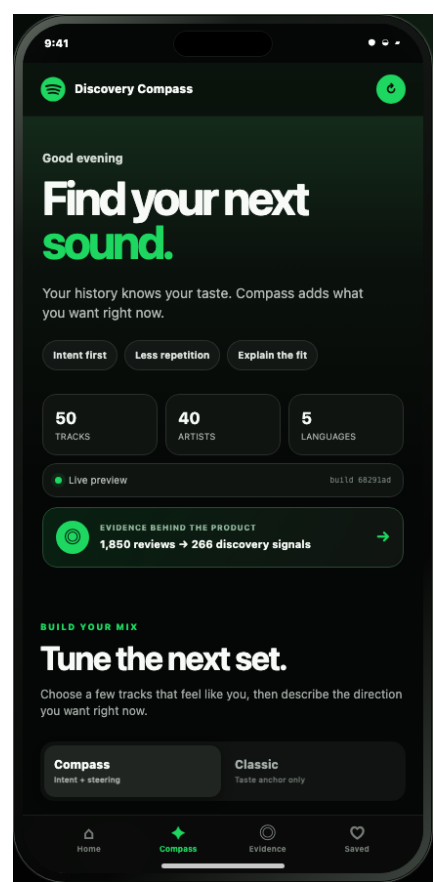


Key flow stages

- The Curiosity Trigger:** Users seek new music, starting hopefully via search or smart shuffle.
- Evaluation & Loss of Control:** Recommendations feel repetitive, leaving users with no visible way to correct them.
- The Frustrating Fallback:** Lacking control, users abandon discovery and retreat to familiar, boring playlists.
- The Discovery Compass Intervention:** The compass intervenes, anchoring choices and capturing the user's exact current intent.
- Active Exploration & Steering:** Users explore 8–12 grounded tracks, actively steering results via direct feedback.
- Meaningful Progress:** This visible control loop builds confidence and delivers successful, relevant music discovery.

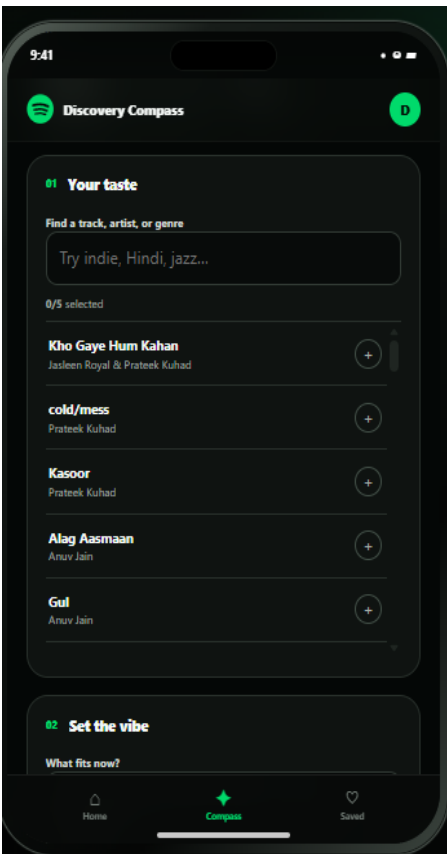


1 • ENTER AND ANCHOR



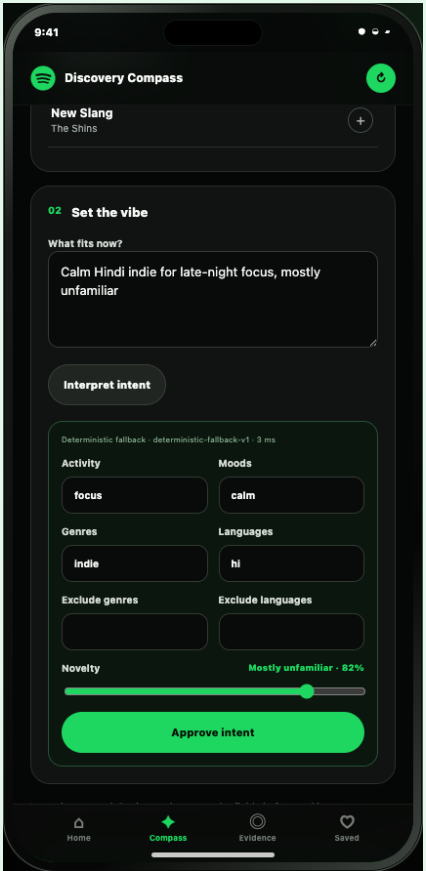
Created a new tab for the user (Compass) old one (Classic)
Sets truthful expectations before asking for effort and makes the experiment condition visible.

2.SET THE VIBES



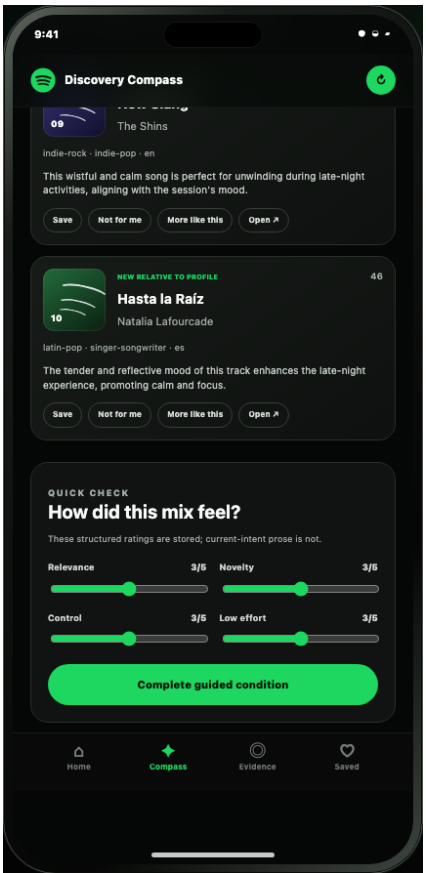
Select your 5 music according to your vibes as intent

3 • APPROVE CURRENT INTENT



Supported preference language maps directly to an editable control; only genuinely unsupported details require review before approval.

4 • EXPLORE AND STEER



Feedback becomes an immediate product-state change rather than an opaque signal for later.



Success Metrics :

North Star Metric: Weekly Qualified Discovery Actions per Weekly Active Discovery User

Measures the % of average number of AI-recommended, previously unconsumed tracks that cross an engaged-listen threshold and generate a save, replay, playlist add, artist follow, or deeper artist exploration within seven days.

Leading Indicators:

METRICS	DEFINATION	WHY IT MATTERS
Discovery Compass adoption rate	% of eligible active users who open the Compass tab	Measures feature reach and initial interest
Intent completion rate	% of users who submit mood/activity/genre/novelty preferences after opening the flow	Validates whether the AI-guided input experience is understandable
Mix generation rate	% of completed intents that generate a discovery mix	Measures technical and UX flow success
New-track play rate	% of recommended tracks that are previously unplayed by the user and started	Indicates willingness to try unfamiliar music
Recommendation explanation engagement	% of users who open or interact with “Why this track?”	Tests whether transparency builds trust

Guardrail Metrics :

Guardrails ensure that increasing discovery does not harm trust, listening quality, or the core Spotify experience.

- Early skip rate:** % of recommendations skipped within 30 seconds.
- Negative feedback rate:** % of tracks marked “Not for me” or hidden.
- Core engagement impact:** No decline in total listening time or playlist completion.

Latency, content-preference violations, recommendation diversity, and impact on existing Spotify listening.

Lagging Indicators :

Metric	Definition	Why it matters
7-day discovery retention	% of users who return to Compass within 7 days	Indicates repeated discovery habit
New artist adoption rate	% of users who listen to a newly discovered artist again within 30 days	Measures deeper exploration beyond one track
Repeat-listening reduction	Change in share of listening time spent on previously repeated tracks	Measures whether repetitive behavior is reducing
Listening diversity index	Change in unique artists, genres, languages, and tracks consumed per user	Measures broader discovery behaviour



Distribution Model

Discovery Compass will be distributed primarily through Spotify’s existing in-app ecosystem, targeting users at moments when repetitive listening behavior is detected.

- In-app placement:** Dedicated “Discovery Compass” tab in Spotify Home/Search.
- Contextual entry points:** Promoted after repeat listening, playlist completion, or repeated artist plays.
- Lifecycle nudges:** Push notifications and in-app cards such as “Your fresh mix is ready.”
- Social sharing:** Users can share AI-generated discovery mixes with friends.

Business Model

Discovery Compass is primarily an **engagement and retention product**, rather than a direct paid feature. Its main business value is increasing meaningful listening, reducing recommendation fatigue, and helping users build stronger music habits on Spotify.

- Freemium engagement lever:** Available to all users to increase listening time and retention.
- Premium conversion:** Free users get limited AI discovery mixes; Premium users get unlimited mixes, advanced filters, and ad-free playback.
- Artist ecosystem value:** Better discovery increases exposure for emerging artists and can improve artist promotion inventory.

Risks and Mitigation

Risk	Mitigation
Low-quality or irrelevant recommendations	Use save rate, skip rate, and “Not for me” feedback to continuously retrain ranking models.
Users do not trust unfamiliar tracks	Show “Why this track?” explanations and allow novelty-level controls.
AI generates inappropriate or incorrect music intent	Apply content-safety filters, explicit-content settings, and user-controlled exclusions.
Feature increases skips and session exits	Start with a small beta cohort and use skip rate and abandonment rate as rollout guardrails.
Existing Spotify discovery surfaces are cannibalized	Run A/B tests and measure incremental meaningful discoveries versus control users.